the guise of Hinduism, even giving him the epithet *pracchanna bauddha*, or ‘Buddhist in disguise’.

Royal patronage was everything, and here the Brahmins held two trump cards. They alone could ensure caste respectability and status, and they alone could provide the seal of sanctification by carrying out their complex rituals and sacrifices, as in the instance of all those royal sacrifices listed on the walls of the Naneghat Cave. Furthermore, the Brahmins had no truck with celibacy and so could hand down their calling from father to son, ensuring continuity and stability. So it was the celibate Jains and the Buddhists who lost out. The increasing withdrawal of royal patronage and public support left the Jains with no option but to rely on their own resources, while many Buddhist monks and nuns retreated to Lanka. Many others, no doubt, did what many of their lay followers must have done, which was to take the easier course of returning to Hinduism.

That many Jain and Buddhist places of worship or retreat became Hindu temples is beyond doubt, but this is more likely to have taken place through simple abandonment rather than forced expulsion. There are scores of places in Kerala that include *palli* as a suffix, which was the original term for a Buddhist *vihara*, which suggests that these were originally Buddhist sites. But then when the first Christians built their churches on the Malabar coast they too used the word *palli*, as did the Muslims in later years. It is simply that *palli* had become the local word for a temple.

That said, the continuing rediscovery of scores of mostly eleventh-and twelfth-century pieces of Buddhist statuary scattered up and down the Tamil heartland, as recounted earlier, does suggest that in some instances these had been taken out and dumped, often with the heads decapitated or defaced. Dr John Samuel, director of the Institute of Asian Studies in Chennai, has reported on more than 150 Buddhist statues or parts of such statues found in close proximity to